

INT. RECORD LABEL OFFICE - DAY

A cluttered A&R office. Gold records line the walls. On a battered turntable, 'Take On Me' by a-ha plays loudly -- that unmistakable synth riff filling the room.

DIANA (40s, sharp) stands at the window, back to us. Her assistant, FELIX (20s, nervous), hovers in the doorway.

FELIX

The Nielsen rep is here. And... he brought lawyers.

DIANA

Of course he did. Turn that off.

Felix crosses to the turntable and lifts the needle.

ANGLE ON -- THE TURNTABLE

The spinning vinyl slows. The label reads: WEA International. A Coca-Cola can sits beside it, logo facing the lens.

INT. RECORD LABEL OFFICE - CONTINUOUS

Diana turns. On the wall behind her hangs Nighthawks by Edward Hopper, a large print in a thin black frame.

DIANA

You know that song? Take On Me? I actually love that song. It reminds me why I got into this business.

FELIX

The Nielsen rep -- his name is Harman. Marcus Harman.

DIANA

(dry)

The Marcus Harman? I thought he

retired.

INT./EXT. DIANA'S CAR - MOVING - LATE AFTERNOON

Diana drives. Felix rides shotgun, scrolling his phone. They pass a brightly lit Nobu restaurant -- Diana glances at it.

FELIX

He says the Coca-Cola deal is dead. They found out about the Pepsi placement last quarter. Now they're threatening to pull their entire catalog.

DIANA

To be, or not to be -- that is the question. Shakespeare said that and it's still the only thing worth saying in a negotiation.

INT. LAW FIRM - CONFERENCE ROOM - NIGHT

A long glass table. MARCUS HARMAN (60s, silver-haired, the actual music industry executive) sits at one end.

Across from him, Diana. Between them, a stack of contracts. A framed poster of Guernica by Pablo Picasso dominates the far wall.

MARCUS

Your client Dr. James Holloway signed a personal guarantee. The debt is real.

DIANA

Dr. Holloway disagrees. And frankly, so do I.

MARCUS

Then we'll let the courts decide. I've been doing this for forty years. I have never lost a contract

dispute.

DIANA
There's always a first time.

I/E. PARKING GARAGE - NIGHT

Diana walks to her car alone. Her footsteps echo. She stops at a concrete pillar. Leans against it. Closes her eyes.

MOMENTS LATER

She opens her eyes. Takes out her phone. Dials.

DIANA
(into phone)
It's me. We need to talk about the
Holloway situation. Meet me at
Nobu. Twenty minutes.

CUT TO:

INT. ALL-NIGHT DINER - LATER

A vinyl booth under a flickering strip light. Felix slides a Coca-Cola bottle across the Formica. Diana does not touch it.

FELIX
I got you a Coke.

DIANA
Coca-Cola tastes like syrup and
battery acid. It rots your teeth
out of your head and they put a
polar bear on the can so nobody
notices. I wouldn't pour it down a
drain.

She pushes the bottle to the far edge of the table.

EXT. NOBU - SIDEWALK - NIGHT

Diana waits under the awning. Felix catches up, out of breath.

FELIX

There's another way through this.
Taylor Swift re-recorded her first
six albums when she couldn't buy
the masters back. Holloway could do
exactly the same thing.

DIANA

Taylor Swift had thirty million
people waiting for her. Holloway
has a lawyer and a mortgage.

FADE OUT.